

GovCon BD Upskilling Program

Customer Engagement Fundamentals

Module 2.2 | Domain D2 (20%)

DURATION

2-3 hours

FORMAT

Live Instructor-Led

GovConGiants

30-Day Foundation Program

Module 2.2: Customer Engagement Fundamentals

Learning Objectives

By the end of this module, learners will be able to:

1. **Identify** key customer touchpoints within federal agencies (OSDBU, contracting offices, program offices)
2. **Explain** the purpose and value of industry days, vendor outreach sessions, and capability briefings
3. **Prepare** for customer interactions using structured research and talking points
4. **Document** engagement activities in a customer engagement plan
5. **Recognize** appropriate and inappropriate engagement practices per FAR guidelines

Required Reading/Viewing

Official Government Resources (Free)

1. **SBA.gov** - “Doing Business with the Federal Government”
 - URL: <https://www.sba.gov/federal-contracting/contracting-guide/how-win-contracts>
 - Focus: Overview of customer engagement pathways
2. **Agency OSDBU Offices** - Office of Small and Disadvantaged Business Utilization
 - URL: Varies by agency (search “[Agency Name] OSDBU”)
 - Focus: Small business outreach programs and events
3. **SAM.gov** - “Industry Days and Events”
 - URL: <https://sam.gov/content/opportunities> (filter by “Special Notice”)
 - Focus: Finding industry day announcements

Action Plan Journal References

- **Contact Agencies:** pages 65-75
- **How to Prepare for Capability Briefings:** page 76
- **Setup Cap Briefings with Top 10 Agencies:** pages 77-86

- **POC Information for Agencies:** pages 57-64
- **Attend OSDBU Recommended Events:** page 119
- **Attend Industry Specific Events:** page 120
- **Attend PTAC Events:** pages 121-128

Lesson Content

1. Why Customer Engagement Matters

In GovCon, contracts are won long before the RFP is released. Building relationships with government customers allows you to:

- **Understand their pain points** before requirements are written
- **Shape requirements** through legitimate market research participation
- **Build trust** so evaluators recognize your company
- **Identify teaming opportunities** through agency introductions
- **Stay informed** about upcoming procurements

Key Principle

The best BD happens before the solicitation drops.

2. Key Customer Touchpoints

Federal agencies have multiple entry points for vendor engagement:

OSDBU	Office of Small & Disadvantaged Business Utilization	Advocate for small business participation	Early/always
Contracting Office	Contracting Officers (COs), Contract Specialists	Issue solicitations, award contracts	After RFI/Sources Sought
Program Office	Mission owners, end users	Define requirements, manage programs	Early market research

Technical Staff	Engineers, analysts, subject matter experts	Evaluate technical solutions	Industry days, demos
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3. Types of Customer Engagement Events

Industry Days

What: Government-hosted events where agencies brief upcoming procurements and vendors can ask questions.

Purpose:

- Government shares acquisition plans
- Vendors learn about requirements
- Networking with government and potential partners
- Q&A with contracting and program staff

How to Find:

- SAM.gov (filter by “Special Notice” or “Presolicitation”)
- Agency OSDBU calendars
- Agency procurement forecast pages

What to Do:

- Research the agency and opportunity beforehand
- Prepare 2-3 thoughtful questions
- Bring business cards and capability statements
- Network with other vendors (potential teammates)

Capability Briefings (Cap Briefs)

What: Short presentations (15-30 minutes) to government officials about your company's capabilities.

Purpose:

- Introduce your company to potential customers
- Educate them on solutions they may not know exist
- Build relationships before opportunities arise

How to Request:

1. Contact the agency OSDBU
2. Request a capability briefing with relevant program or contracting offices
3. Prepare a focused, non-salesy presentation

4. Follow up appropriately

Best Practices:

- Focus on solving their problems, not selling your services
- Keep it short and relevant
- Bring something useful (industry insights, not just a sales pitch)
- Don't ask about specific opportunities (that's inappropriate)

Vendor Outreach Sessions

What: Agency-hosted sessions for small businesses or specific vendor categories.

Purpose:

- Agencies fulfill their small business outreach requirements
- Vendors learn about the agency's mission and needs
- Matchmaking between primes and small businesses

Where to Find:

- OSDBU event calendars
- Agency small business conferences
- Apex Accelerator announcements

4. OSDBU: Your Gateway to Agencies

Every major federal agency has an **Office of Small and Disadvantaged Business Utilization (OSDBU)**.

What OSDBU Does for You:

- Hosts matchmaking events
- Connects small businesses with program offices
- Provides guidance on agency procurement
- Tracks agency small business goals
- Advocates for small business participation

How to Engage:

1. Find the agency's OSDBU contact page
2. Attend their events and webinars
3. Request introduction to relevant program offices
4. Ask about upcoming forecast opportunities
5. Register for their vendor database (if applicable)

Major Agency OSDBU Pages:

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DoD	business.defense.gov/osbp
VA	va.gov/osdbu
HHS	hhs.gov/grants/contracts/small-business
DHS	dhs.gov/small-business
GSA	gsa.gov/small-business
DOE	energy.gov/osdbu
NASA	nasa.gov/osbp

5. Preparing for Customer Engagement

Before Any Engagement:

1	Research the agency's mission	Show you understand their world
2	Review recent contract awards (SAM.gov Contract Data)	Know what they buy
3	Check their procurement forecast	Know what's coming
4	Prepare your elevator pitch	30-second company overview
5	Bring capability statement	Leave-behind document
6	Prepare questions	Show genuine interest

Your Elevator Pitch Formula:

Elevator Pitch Template

"We're [Company Name], a [business type/certification] company that helps federal agencies [solve specific problem]. We've supported [relevant customers] with [relevant work]. We're particularly interested in [their mission area]."

Example:

"We're TechForward Solutions, a service-disabled veteran-owned small business that helps federal agencies modernize legacy IT systems. We've supported the VA and DoD with cloud migration and cybersecurity. We're particularly interested in DHS's IT modernization initiatives."

6. Rules of Engagement (Ethics & Compliance)

Federal procurement has strict rules about vendor-government interactions. Know the boundaries.

Appropriate Engagement:

- Attending public industry days
- Responding to RFIs and Sources Sought notices
- Requesting OSDBU capability briefings
- Asking general questions about agency mission
- Sharing industry insights (not proprietary)
- Networking at public events

Inappropriate Engagement:

- Asking about specific pending source selections
- Offering gifts or meals to government employees
- Attempting to influence evaluation criteria inappropriately
- Discussing competitor bids or pricing
- Contacting evaluators during source selection
- Providing false or misleading information

Procurement Integrity Act (FAR 3.104)

The Procurement Integrity Act prohibits:

- Obtaining contractor bid or proposal information
- Obtaining source selection information
- Improper contact with procurement officials

Rule of Thumb: If it feels like you're trying to gain an unfair advantage, don't do it.

7. Documenting Customer Engagement

Track all customer interactions in a structured format:

What to Document:

- Date and type of engagement
- Agency and office contacted
- Names and titles of government contacts
- Topics discussed
- Follow-up actions committed
- Intelligence gathered
- Next steps

Why Document:

- Builds institutional knowledge
- Supports capture planning
- Enables team coordination
- Demonstrates relationship history in proposals
- Tracks commitments and follow-ups

AI Accelerator: Using AI for Customer Engagement

AI tools can help you prepare for customer meetings, craft elevator pitches, and develop engagement strategies.

Prompt 1: Research an Agency Before Engagement

Use When: You have a meeting or event with a specific agency.

I have a meeting with representatives from [AGENCY NAME] next week.
Help me prepare by providing:

1. The agency's core mission and strategic priorities
2. Recent news or initiatives I should know about
3. Common pain points agencies like this typically face
4. Questions I should ask to understand their needs
5. Topics to avoid or be careful discussing
6. How to position a company that provides [YOUR SERVICES]

I'll verify current details on the agency website.

Prompt 2: Craft Your Elevator Pitch

Use When: You need a concise company introduction for networking.

Help me create a 30-second elevator pitch for government customers.

Our company:

- Name: [COMPANY NAME]
- Size/Certifications: [e.g., SDVOSB, 8(a), small business]
- Core services: [WHAT YOU DO]
- Target agencies: [WHO YOU SERVE]

- Key differentiator: [WHAT MAKES YOU DIFFERENT]
- Recent win or achievement: [PROOF POINT]

Create 3 versions:

1. General networking version
2. Version for [SPECIFIC AGENCY]
3. Version emphasizing our [CERTIFICATION] status

Keep each under 30 seconds when spoken aloud.

Prompt 3: Prepare Capability Briefing Talking Points

Use When: You're preparing for a capability briefing with an agency.

I'm preparing a capability briefing for [AGENCY NAME]'s OSD BU.
Our company provides [YOUR SERVICES].

Help me develop:

1. An opening hook that connects to their mission
2. 3-5 key capability points to emphasize
3. A relevant past performance example to mention
4. 2-3 questions to ask them (that are appropriate)
5. A clear call-to-action for next steps
6. Topics to avoid (what NOT to discuss)

Remember: This is educational, not a sales pitch.

Prompt 4: Draft Industry Day Questions

Use When: You're attending an industry day and want to ask smart questions.

I'm attending an industry day for this upcoming procurement:

[PASTE INDUSTRY DAY ANNOUNCEMENT OR PROCUREMENT DESCRIPTION]

Our company provides [YOUR SERVICES] and we're interested in pursuing this.

Help me prepare:

1. 3-5 thoughtful questions to ask during Q&A
2. Questions that show we understand their challenges
3. Questions that might reveal evaluation priorities
4. Networking conversation starters for other attendees
5. What to listen for during the briefing

Questions should be appropriate (not asking for source selection info).

Pro Tips for AI-Assisted Customer Engagement

Use AI to prepare talking points and research	Let AI write emails you send without review
Practice elevator pitches generated by AI	Use AI-generated content word-for-word
Get AI help with follow-up email drafts	Ask AI about specific procurement details
Research agency priorities with AI assistance	Skip verifying info on agency websites

Remember

AI helps you prepare, but authentic relationships come from genuine human interaction. Use AI to be better prepared, not to replace personal connection.

Applied Exercise: Build Your Customer Engagement Plan

Scenario: Your company wants to increase its presence with a specific federal agency. Your manager asks you to develop a 90-day customer engagement plan.

Part 1: Select Your Target Agency

Choose ONE agency from this list (or one relevant to your company):

- Department of Veterans Affairs (VA)
- Department of Homeland Security (DHS)
- Department of Health and Human Services (HHS)
- General Services Administration (GSA)
- Department of Energy (DOE)

Part 2: Research the Agency

1. Find the agency's OSDBU website
2. Look for upcoming events or vendor outreach sessions
3. Review any industry day announcements on SAM.gov
4. Check the agency's procurement forecast (if available)

Part 3: Identify Engagement Opportunities

List at least 3 specific engagement opportunities:

- Industry days
- OSDBU events
- Capability briefing requests
- Vendor outreach sessions

Part 4: Prepare Your Engagement Plan

Use the Work Artifact template to document:

- Target contacts
- Planned activities
- Timeline (90 days)
- Preparation needed
- Expected outcomes

Time: 45-60 minutes

Work Artifact: Customer Engagement Plan

Plan Header

Your Name: _____

Date: _____

Target Agency: _____

Section 1: Agency Overview

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Agency Name	
Mission Summary	
OSDBU Website	
Key OSDBU Contact	
Recent Procurement Focus	

Section 2: Engagement Opportunities Identified

1			
2			
3			

Section 3: 90-Day Engagement Timeline

Days 1-30			
Days 31-60			
Days 61-90			

Section 4: Elevator Pitch Draft

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Section 5: Expected Outcomes

Knowledge Check (Self-Assessment)

Question 1 (Recall)

What does OSDBU stand for?

- A) Office of Small and Diversified Business Utilization
- B) **Office of Small and Disadvantaged Business Utilization**
- C) Office of Strategic and Defense Business Units
- D) Office of Supply and Demand Business Understanding

Correct Answer: B

Question 2 (Application)

You want to introduce your company to a federal agency before any specific opportunities are announced. What is the most appropriate first step?

- A) Email the contracting officer directly
- B) **Contact the agency's OSDBU to request a capability briefing**
- C) Wait for an RFP to be released
- D) Send unsolicited proposals to program offices

Correct Answer: B

Question 3 (Scenario)

You're at an industry day, and a government program manager mentions they're frustrated with their current contractor's slow response times. How should you respond?

- A) Immediately criticize the competitor and pitch your faster services
- B) **Ask probing questions to understand their challenges, then follow up appropriately after the event**
- C) Ask who the current contractor is so you can prepare to compete
- D) Offer to meet privately to discuss how to replace the incumbent

Correct Answer: B

Question 4 (Application)

Which of the following is NOT an appropriate topic for a capability briefing?

- A) Your company's relevant experience and certifications
- B) Industry trends and best practices
- C) **Asking about evaluation criteria for an upcoming RFP**
- D) How your solutions have helped similar agencies

Correct Answer: C

Question 5 (Recall)

What federal regulation governs procurement integrity and prohibits improper contact with procurement officials?

- A) FAR Part 15
- B) **FAR 3.104 (Procurement Integrity Act)**
- C) FAR Part 52
- D) FAR Part 19

Correct Answer: B

Manager Discussion Prompts

1. **Current Context:** "What agencies does our company have existing relationships with? Are there specific contacts I should know about?"
2. **Application:** "Are there upcoming industry days or OSDBU events I should attend? How do we currently track customer engagement activities?"
3. **Career Development:** "How can I support customer engagement efforts even if I'm not in a BD role?"

Completion Criteria

To complete this module:

- ☐ Read all required materials (approximately 20 minutes)
- ☐ Complete the lesson content review (30-45 minutes)
- ☐ Finish the Applied Exercise (agency research and engagement planning)
- ☐ Submit a Customer Engagement Plan with at least 3 opportunities identified

- [] Review the Knowledge Check questions (self-assessment)
- [] Participate in manager discussion (or document self-reflection)

Estimated Total Time: 2-3 hours

Additional Resources

Key Terms

OSDBU: Office of Small and Disadvantaged Business Utilization

Industry Day: Government-hosted event to brief upcoming procurements

Capability Briefing: Vendor presentation to government about company capabilities

Matchmaking Event: Session connecting primes with potential small business partners

Procurement Integrity Act: FAR 3.104 rules governing ethical vendor-government interactions

Elevator Pitch: 30-second company overview for networking

Action Plan Journal Activities

After completing this module, use your **Action Plan Journal** to:

1. Complete **POC Information for Agencies** sheets (pages 57-64) for your target agency
2. Use **How to Prepare for Capability Briefings** (page 76) as your preparation checklist
3. Schedule briefings using **Setup Cap Briefings with Top 10 Agencies** (pages 77-86)
4. Track events using **Attend OSDBU Recommended Events** (page 119)
5. Register with your local PTAC and track using **Attend PTAC Events** (pages 121-128)

Journal Reference

The Customer Engagement Plan you completed connects directly to the Contact Agencies section (pages 65-75) in your Action Plan Journal. Transfer your plan to maintain a single tracking system.